

Dr Weliton Menário Costa (Dr WELI)

Scientist-artist · Creative director · Founder, WildWooHoo

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Citizenship: **Italian (EU)** · Brazilian · Australian Languages: Portuguese (native), English (fluent), Spanish (intermediate)

Profile

Creative director and singer-songwriter working in contemporary popular music, from a doctorate in behavioural ecology. I coined and defined **sci pop**: using science and scientific thinking for innovation in the aesthetics, narrative, making and performance of contemporary pop music. I direct, and I perform in what I direct. Sixteen years in scientific inquiry and substantial experience translating it into art. My Honorary Visiting Fellowship at the ANU Centre for the Public Awareness of Science carries the research line **science in music and popular culture**.

Already working in Europe

- **German public television.** UFA Show & Factual GmbH (Cologne, a Fremantle company) licensed the *Kangaroo Time* footage in 2024 for *Wer weiß denn sowas?!* (ARD, Das Erste), illustrating a quiz question on the research behind it. Four-year licence, credited “WELI - Kangaroo Time, from ANU”.
 - **German press.** *Süddeutsche Zeitung* covered *Kangaroo Time*, 2024: sueddeutsche.de/panorama/kaenguru-tiere-doktorarbeit-kurioses-anruf-bei-australien-1.6401819.
 - **Athens Science Festival**, with SciCo Greece, May 2025. My workshop *Science and the People*, delivered to a European audience.
 - **Falling Walls Engage**, Berlin, 2025. **Top 30 worldwide**, for *Science for the People*.
 - **Italian citizenship**, so no visa, permit or sponsorship is required to work or travel in the EU.
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The doctorate, and the work made from it

- **PhD, Ecology and Evolution**, The Australian National University, 2017 to 2021. Supervisors: Prof. Loeske Kruuk (ANU) and Prof. Marco Festa-Bianchet (Université de Sherbrooke). Thesis: *Personality, social environment, and maternal-level effects: insights from a wild kangaroo population* (266 pp). Published as Menário Costa et al. (2023), *Behavioral Ecology* 34(6), 1002 to 1012.
 - **Kangaroo Time (2024) was made from that research.** The song I co-wrote and the film I wrote, cast, directed and performed, with a dance cast of twenty-four drawn from multicultural Canberra. **AAAS Dance Your PhD Overall Winner 2024**, the overall prize across all four categories. [Watch](#) · [Kids edit](#)
 - **238+ media features across five continents**, including The Guardian, Smithsonian Magazine, NPR, BBC, *Science* and *Cosmos* (Isentia 2024), and **MSNBC The 11th Hour** in the United States.
 - **Its reception is why I founded WildWooHoo**, the studio I direct, to give the method a standing home.
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Selected creative work

- **Cabra da Peste (G.O.A.T.)** (2024). Original Latin pop song built from my undergraduate research on goat social hierarchy, commissioned for and performed at the [opening plenary](#) of the XLI Encontro Anual de Etologia, Brazil, on the theme “Creativity and Science unifying communities”. Co-written and performed with Jon Panic (Black Bird Hum).
- **Yours Academically, Dr. WELI** (EP, released). Science, queer and Latin-immigrant narratives across reggaeton, electronic and Brazilian funk.
- **EVER+GROW**. First sci pop album. **In development**.
- **The Photography Project** (shot 2023, released 2024). Staged portrait series translating the doctoral findings into people. Concept and creative direction mine; photographed by Tony Oliver and Reid Workman.

- **Released catalogue:** drweli.com/music. **APRA AMCOS** songwriter member since 2023 · **Australian Independent Record Labels Association (AIR)**, Artist member since 2026 · listed in the [artsACT Artist Database](#).

Selected performance and public programming

- **Co-host, *The Visionaries Among Us***, ANU 80th anniversary, Manning Clark Hall, August 2026, with Lee Constable. Program spanning deep human history, large language models and deep space.
- **Opening plenary performance**, Encontro Anual de Etologia, Brazil, 2024.
- **Kangaroo Time Kids**. Schools workshop built from *Kangaroo Time*, teaching the behavioural science through music and dance directly to children.
- **Floriade**, Canberra, 2025 · **Three Minute Thesis half-time show**, Llewellyn Hall, ANU, 2024 · **ACT National Science Week**, 2024 and 2025, with Inspiring Australia ACT · **ANU HDR Research Festival** · **Guest lecture**, ANU Centre for the Public Awareness of Science · **ANU Commencement 2025**, co-master of ceremonies · **Canberra Multicultural Festival**.

Research

- **Honorary Visiting Fellow**, [Centre for the Public Awareness of Science](#), ANU, 2025 to 2027, renewed for a second term. Research line: science in music and popular culture. Collaborator: Dr Anna-Sophie Jürgens. Oversight: Prof. Sujatha Raman.
- **sci pop**, the founding text, deposited and citable: doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.21387515.
- *Principles of effective engagement with music in and for science communication*, with Anna-Sophie Jürgens, Graham Walker and Gypsy Cook (ANU CPAS). **In preparation**, using *Kangaroo Time* as a worked case.
- Jürgens, Fiadotava, Menário Costa & Judd, chapter on aliens, camp science and science communication in film, for a Routledge volume on humour in science communication. **In preparation**.
- Menário Costa, King, Bonnet, Festa-Bianchet & Kruuk (2023). Early-life behavior, survival, and maternal personality in a wild marsupial. *Behavioral Ecology* 34(6), 1002 to 1012.

Recognition

- **AAAS Dance Your PhD Overall Winner 2024**, for *Kangaroo Time*. AU\$4,000.
- **Falling Walls Engage Top 30 worldwide 2025**, for *Science for the People*.
- **Judge**, Dance Your PhD, 2025.

Positions and education

- **Founder and Creative Director**, WildWooHoo, 2026 to present.
- **Research Data Scientist**, UNSW, 2025 to 2026 · **University Tutor**, Research School of Biology, ANU, 2019 to 2021.
- **Voice and songwriting**, Open Academy, Sydney Conservatorium of Music, University of Sydney, four short courses, 2025 to 2026. Private voice and performance coaching, ANU School of Music and NIDA short courses.
- **Licenciatura and Bacharelado, Biological Sciences**, [Instituto Federal do Espírito Santo](#), Brazil, from 2010, with a Science Without Borders exchange at Griffith University, Australia, 2013 to 2014.

Funding

- **Social Policy Group**, 2024. AU\$20,000 excl. GST, for events combining science and music for culturally and linguistically diverse communities.
- **ACT National Science Week / Inspiring Australia ACT**, 2024. AU\$1,700, for *Cabra da Peste*.
- **Holsworth Wildlife Research Endowment**, 2017 to 2020. Field-research funding for the kangaroo doctorate.
- **ANU International PhD Scholarship**, 2017 to 2020, and **ANU HDR Fee Remission Merit Scholarship**, 2017 to 2021.

Capabilities

Creative direction · songwriting · live performance and dance · research translation · film concept and direction · workshop design and facilitation · experimental design, field data collection, quantitative analysis and scientific writing · working in three languages.